

Think Before You Click

Phishing Detection & Awareness Report

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- 🔒 • Never share OTPs or passwords
- ✉️ • Double-check email senders
- ⚠️ • Don't click unknown links or attachments
- ✓ • Use verified apps and website
- 🚨 • Report suspicious messages immediately

Stay Alert. Stay Safe. Report Cybercrime

Executive Summary

Phishing is one of the most common cyber threats targeting individuals and organizations. Attackers use deceptive emails to trick users into revealing sensitive information, clicking malicious links, or downloading harmful attachments.

This report presents a security awareness analysis of a simulated phishing email. The assessment identifies common phishing indicators, explains the techniques used by attackers, classifies the email's risk level, and provides practical recommendations to help users recognize and avoid phishing attacks.

The objective of this report is to improve cybersecurity awareness by demonstrating how phishing emails can be identified through careful inspection of the sender, email content, links, and social engineering tactics.

What is Phishing?

Phishing is a type of cyber attack where attackers send fake emails that appear to come from trusted organizations, such as banks, online services, or company departments. Their goal is to trick people into clicking malicious links, downloading harmful attachments, or sharing sensitive information like passwords, credit card details, or one-time passwords (OTPs). These emails often create a sense of urgency or fear to pressure users into acting quickly without verifying the message. Because of this, phishing remains one of the most effective attack methods and is a common cause of security incidents in many organizations.

Sample Email

From: Microsoft Security <security@ms-security-alert.com>

To: employee@company.com

Subject: Immediate Action Required: Verify Your Microsoft 365 Account

Date: July 27, 2026

Dear Employee,

We detected unusual activity on your Microsoft 365 account. To protect your account from being suspended, please verify your identity within the next 24 hours.

Click the link below to verify your account:

<https://ms365-account-verify.com>

Failure to complete the verification process may result in temporary account suspension.

If you believe you have already verified your account, please ignore this message.

Regards,

Microsoft Security Team

Figure 1. Simulated phishing email used for analysis.

Email Analysis

1. Sender Analysis

Email Address:

security@ms-security-alert.com

Analysis:

The sender claims to represent Microsoft Security, but the domain ms-security-alert.com is not an official Microsoft domain. Legitimate Microsoft emails are typically sent from trusted domains such as microsoft.com or microsoftonline.com. This difference is a strong indicator that the email may be fraudulent.

2. Subject Analysis

Subject:

Immediate Action Required: Verify Your Microsoft 365 Account

Analysis:

The subject creates a sense of urgency by encouraging the recipient to act immediately. Attackers commonly use urgent language to pressure users into making quick decisions without verifying the email.

3. URL Analysis

URL:

<https://ms365-account-verify.com>

Analysis:

The link does not belong to an official Microsoft domain. Instead, it uses a misleading domain name that attempts to imitate Microsoft's branding. Users should always verify website addresses before entering any personal or login information.

4. Phishing Indicators (Red Flags)

-  The sender uses an unofficial domain.
-  The email creates urgency by threatening account suspension.
-  The embedded link points to a suspicious website.
-  The message requests immediate account verification.
-  The greeting is generic ("Dear Employee") instead of using the recipient's name.

5. Risk Classification

Classification: Phishing

Reason:

The email contains multiple phishing indicators, including a spoofed sender, a deceptive URL, urgent language, and a request for immediate action. These characteristics strongly suggest an attempt to steal user credentials.

Prevention Guidelines

- *Verify the sender's email address.*
- *Hover over links before clicking.*
- *Never share passwords or OTPs.*
- *Report suspicious emails to the IT/Security team.*
- *Enable Multi-Factor Authentication .*

Conclusion

Phishing emails remain one of the most common cybersecurity threats because they target people rather than systems. This analysis showed how suspicious sender information, deceptive links, urgent language, and generic greetings can be used to trick users into revealing sensitive information.

By carefully checking these warning signs and following basic security practices, users can significantly reduce the risk of becoming victims of phishing attacks.

Regular security awareness and cautious email handling are essential for protecting both individuals and organizations from cyber threats.